Handicrafts of Tamil Nadu

Every region of Tamil Nadu boasts its own unique handicraft traditions, which have been preserved carefully since ancient times.

From humble Golu dolls made of clay and wood to dazzling gold-leaf paintings, Tamil Nadu has a long and glorious handicrafts tradition that has been preserved and nurtured to the present day. Did you know that Tamil Nadu has the highest number of GI tags among other Indian states? Of course, the GI-tagged products include handicrafts, many of which have been crafted in Tamil Nadu for centuries. These include everything from Thanjavur paintings to Dindigul locks, Swamimalai bronze icons, Toda embroidery, Thanjavur art plates, Mamallapuram stone sculptures, temple jewellery of Nagercoil, Arumbavur wood carvings and many more. Many handicrafts also reflect their respective regions, such as the seashell handicrafts of Kanniyakumari.

One of Tamil Nadu's most coveted crafts is the Thanjavur gold leaf painting. Also known as Thanjavur painting, it features Hindu god, goddess and stories from the epics. The speciality of the painting is its exquisite ornamentation, done with gold leaf, gilded metal pieces and semi-precious stones which embellish the figures in the painting. Another unique craftmanship from Thanjavur is the Thanjavur art plate, a circular metal plate exclusively made by the Vishwakarma community. It's a metal plate of silver, bronze or copper embossed with figures of gods and goddesses at the centre. The plate was introduced by Rajah Serfoji-II (1777–1832) during the Maratha rule.

Tamil Nadu celebrates Golu during Navratri time. The festival sees displays of brightly coloured Golu dolls made by village artisans from wood and clay which tell the story of Dussehra through thematic scenes. Golu displays often take on a pyramidal shape that is reminiscent of the monumental entrance towers of temples in Tamil Nadu.



Tamil Nadu's famous Chola bronzes are named after the flourishing period of the Chola era. The religious sculptures are still made today, using the time honoured lost-wax technique and you can easily find excellent examples to buy.

The Toda community of the Nilgiris is noted for a unique style of embroidery called *'pugur'* or *'pukhoo'* which means flower. Made by the womenfolk, the long shawls or *poothkuli* feature bold floral motifs and animal and human figures in neat geometric patterns. Woven in cotton, silk, wool and jute, the Bhawani Jamakkalam (durries) of the Coimbatore district in Tamil Nadu are noted for their traditional designs and have been around for about two hundred years. The Pattamadai silk mats come from a small village in Tirunelveli district. Featuring intricate designs, the mats are made from a grass called *korai/gorai*. The manufacturing method requires patience, since the grass has to be dried, soaked, split and dyed before being woven.

Tamil Nadu's artisans are skilled in pottery. While Vellore is famed for black and red earthenwares, Usilampatti in Madurai district boasts an old tradition of black pottery. Panruti in Cuddalore district creatively uses local clay to make deities and toys. The famed 'magic pots' of Karigiri in Vellore district stand apart for their distinctive colours and glazes. Designed for the Nawabs of Arcot, the pots are filled with holes in the bottom but don't leak once turned upright, hence the name. Tamil Nadu is also noted for its terracotta work, including the impressive Ayyanar horses which can be seen guarding many villages.

While there are many wood carving traditions in Tamil Nadu, the one in Thammampatti in the Salem region is distinctive. The highly skilled community of wood carvers work with locally available woods to create religious figures and traditional panels.

Chettinad is where the beautiful Athangudi tiles are still made the traditional way. The beautiful patterned tiles make a great souvenir, and you can even order a custom design for your house.

Handicrafts are a great window into the traditions of any destination and Tamil Nadu is no exception. A thoughtful purchase will serve as a lasting reminder of Tamil Nadu's culture, keeping the memories of your visit alive back home.









